

Valerie Polad, M.A.

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Education

Ph.D., Quantitative Psychology

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Expected May 2027

- Advisor: Dr. Dan Bauer
- Dissertation: A Reconsideration of the Hierarchical Linear Model for Estimating Reliable Individual Change

M.A., Quantitative Psychology

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
May 2025

- Thesis: [Mediation Analysis Using Saturated and Restricted Models](#)

B.A., Psychology, Cognitive Science Minor

University of California, Los Angeles
June 2020

- Specialization in Computing

Teaching

Instructor of Record – Psychology 210 (Statistical Principles of Psychological Research)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Spring 2026, Summer 2026, Fall 2026, Spring 2027 (scheduled)

- Undergraduate psychological statistics course
- Taught course in R/RStudio to 35–45 students per semester
- Overall effective instructor rating: 4.45 out of 5 (Spring 2026)

Teaching Assistant – Psychology 831 (Statistical Methods in Psychology II)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Spring 2023, Spring 2024, Spring 2025

- Instructors: Drs. Dan Bauer (2023, 2025) and Patrick Curran (2024)
- Graduate regression course
- Graded assignments and held weekly recitations and office hours to review homework, provide live instructional demonstrations in R/RStudio, and clarify sticking points from lectures
- Overall effective instructor ratings: 4.55–5.00 out of 5

Teaching Assistant – Psychology 830 (Statistical Methods in Psychology I)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Fall 2022, Fall 2023, Fall 2024

- Instructor: Dr. Patrick Harrison
- Graduate ANOVA course
- Graded assignments and held weekly recitations and office hours to review homework, provide live instructional demonstrations in R/RStudio, and clarify sticking points from lectures
- Overall effective instructor ratings: 4.50–4.89 out of 5

Instructional Aide – ICPSR Summer Program: Introduction to MLM and Advanced MLM

University of Michigan, Ann Arbor

Summer 2023, Summer 2024, Summer 2025

- Instructors: Drs. Mark Manning (Intro to MLM) and John Poe (Advanced MLM)
- Courses for faculty, postdoctoral researchers, and graduate students, offered by the Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR)
- Provided statistical consulting, graded assignments, and held office hours
- Created R .html tutorials for conducting multilevel and latent growth curve models in R

Teaching Assistant – Psychology 210 (Statistical Principles of Psychological Research)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Summer 2022, Fall 2022, Summer 2023, Fall 2025

- Instructors: Drs. Patrick Harrison (2021, 2022) and Natasha Parikh (2023, 2025)
- Undergraduate psychological statistics course
- Graded assignments, attended course lectures, and provided direct instructional support with the statistical software Jamovi during lab sessions

Guest Lecturer – Psychology 210 (Statistical Principles of Psychological Research)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

November 2022

- Instructor: Dr. Patrick Harrison
- Delivered a guest lecture on ANOVA to 200+ students

Graduate Research Consultant and Guest Lecturer – Psychology 528 (Clinical Research)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Fall 2022

- Instructor: Dr. Desiree Griffin
- Undergraduate clinical research course
- Served as statistical consultant for undergraduates working on group research projects
- Delivered guest lectures on linear and logistic regression, then met with student groups individually to help them complete their analyses and write up results

Graduate Research Consultant – Psychology 532H (Quantitative Psychology)

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Spring 2022

- Instructor: Dr. Patrick Curran
- Undergraduate honors quantitative psychology course
- Coordinated the distribution of students' self-designed measurement scales via Qualtrics and cleaned the resulting data for student use

Course Assistant – Psychology 100A (Psychological Statistics)

University of California, Los Angeles

Spring 2020

- Instructor: Dr. Craig Enders
- Undergraduate psychological statistics course
- Held office hours and monitored class email and Zoom chat during lectures for students

Workshops

Teaching Assistant – ICPSR QUEST: Introduction to Multilevel Modeling

Norfolk State University, Virginia

Summer 2025

- Instructor: Dr. Mark Manning
- Workshop for undergraduate students, offered through an ICPSR [partnership program with Norfolk State University](#) that brings methods workshops to local students

Teaching Assistant – Data Matters: Data Science Short Course Series

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

August 2022, August 2023, August 2024

- Data science short courses: Machine Learning in R, Introduction to R, and Data Visualizations in R
- Sponsored by the Odum Institute at UNC, the National Consortium on Data Science, and RENCI (Renaissance Computing Institute)

Mentoring

Research Mentor

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

2023 – Present

- Chang (Nala) Shi, undergraduate researcher (2026 – Present; co-mentored by Zach Vig)
- Laura Claire Walker, post-baccalaureate researcher, Winston Center (2026 – Present)
- Suryaduti Baral (2023); now a quantitative psychology Ph.D. student at the University of California, Davis

Research

Graduate Researcher

L. L. Thurstone Psychometric Laboratory, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

August 2021 – Present

- Advisor: Dr. Dan Bauer
- Dissertation research using Monte Carlo simulation to compare the reliable change index (RCI) with empirical Bayes slope estimates from hierarchical linear models for detecting individual change, with Drs. Dan Bauer and Jean-Philippe Laurenceau
- M.A. thesis research on mediation analysis using saturated and restricted models

Data Analyst – Winston Center

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

June 2026 – Present

- Supervisors: Drs. Mitch Prinstein, Anne Maheux, Kaitlyn Burnell
- Clean, analyze, and visualize data in R for studies of AI and technology use in adolescent populations
- Conduct scale development and psychometric modeling for the NC Phones and Tech in Schools Study (NCPTS), a longitudinal study of middle school students nested within schools, including factor analysis, longitudinal measurement invariance, and cross-lagged panel models in R and Mplus
- Conduct multilevel mediation analyses of daily diary and ecological momentary assessment (EMA) data on AI use and well-being
- Provide statistical consulting on dyadic (actor–partner interdependence model) analyses of parent–child data for the FACES study

Data Analyst – Office of Undergraduate Education

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

January 2023 – June 2024

- Supervisor: Dr. Abigail Panter
- Cleaned, analyzed, and visualized data in R pertaining to UNC undergraduate education

Research Assistant – Quantitative Research Collaboratory (QRClab)

University of California, Los Angeles

March 2019 – April 2021

- Principal Investigator: Dr. Amanda Kay Montoya
- Worked with Jessica Fossum (then a graduate student in the lab) to conduct mass coding of journal articles that used moderated mediation analyses; the database of all coded articles is available [here](#)

Psychology Research Opportunity Program (PROPS)

University of California, Los Angeles

January 2020 – June 2020

- Faculty Mentor: Dr. Amanda Kay Montoya
- Graduate Student Mentor: Dr. Chelsea Romney
- Program Faculty Mentor: Dr. Jaana Juvonen
- Conducted an individual research project investigating reducing carryover effects in within-subject designs using Item Response Theory; presentation available at the [UCLA Undergraduate Research Showcase](#)

Published Articles

Buchanan, L. B., Hogan, K. A., Hussong, A. M., Panter, A. T., **Polad, V.**, Sathy, V., Siedentop, N., & Wise, E. H. (2023). An inclusive approach to transitioning to a research university: A college thriving course. *Scholarship of Teaching and Learning in Psychology*, 9(4), 450–479.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/stl0000394>

Janovsky, T., Rock, A. J., Thorsteinsson, E. B., Clark, G. I., **Polad, V.**, & Cosh, S. (2023). Assessing the relationship between early maladaptive schemas and interpersonal problems using interpersonal scenarios depicting rejection. *PLOS ONE*, 18(10), e0288543.
<https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0288543>

Published Abstracts

Polad, V., Bauer, D. J., & Laurenceau, J.-P. (in press). A reconsideration of the hierarchical linear model for estimating reliable individual change. *Multivariate Behavioral Research*.

Poster Presentations

Polad, V., Bauer, D. J., & Laurenceau, J.-P. (2026, October). *A reconsideration of the hierarchical linear model for estimating reliable individual change* [Poster presentation]. Annual Meeting of the Society of Multivariate Experimental Psychology, Durango, CO, United States.

Polad, V., Bauer, D. J., & Laurenceau, J.-P. (2026, June). *A reconsideration of the hierarchical linear model for estimating reliable individual change* [Poster presentation]. Modern Modeling Methods Conference, New York, NY, United States.

Polad, V. (2025, July). *Mediation analysis using saturated and restricted models* [Poster presentation]. International Meeting of the Psychometric Society, Minneapolis, MN, United States.

Polad, V., & Montoya, A. K. (2020, November). *Reducing carryover effects in within-subject designs—Simulation study results* [Poster presentation]. Electronic Undergraduate Statistics Research Conference.

Polad, V., & Montoya, A. K. (2020, May). *Reducing carryover effects in within-subject designs* [Poster presentation]. UCLA Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference. <https://osf.io/njrym/>

Oral Presentations

Polad, V. (2024, April). *SEMantics: Mediation using restricted and unrestricted models* [Invited talk]. King's College London, London, United Kingdom.

Polad, V., & Montoya, A. K. (2020, June). *Reducing carryover effects in within-subject designs* [Paper presentation]. UCLA Undergraduate Research Week, University of California, Los Angeles.

Coursework

PSYC 793 – Laboratory in College Teaching

PSYC 830 – ANOVA

PSYC 831 – Regression

PSYC 834 – Machine Learning

PSYC 838 – Regression with Categorical Dependent Variables

PSYC 842 – Test Theory

PSYC 843 – Factor Analysis

PSYC 844 – Structural Equation Modeling

PSYC 845 – Longitudinal Structural Equation Modeling

PSYC 846 – Multilevel Models

PSYC 848 – Missing Data Analysis Seminar

PSYC 859 – Mediation Analysis

Psych 256A – Multilevel Models (UCLA)

Service

Ad Hoc Reviewer

PLOS ONE

2025 – Present

- Reviewed applied manuscripts, focusing on the appropriateness of analytic choices and clarity of statistical reporting

Panelist – Introduction to Multilevel Modeling Graduate Student Panel

Virtual

June 2026

- Instructor: Dr. Mark Manning
- Answered questions from students in ICPSR course about best practices when conducting MLMs

Panelist – Gil Internship Graduate Student Panel

Department of Psychology and Neuroscience, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

2024, 2025

- Introduced my research and answered Gil interns' questions about graduate school

Panelist – Psi Chi Graduate School Panel

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

March 2024

- Hosted a table at a career-fair-style event, talking with undergraduates about applying to graduate school, the transition to graduate study, and research opportunities

Quant Forum Coordinator

UNC Quantitative Psychology

August 2023 – May 2024

- Scheduled weekly colloquium series for the quantitative program

Panelist – Psychology Research Opportunity Program Alumni Panel

University of California, Los Angeles (virtual)

May 2021

- Shared tips on graduate school with current PROPs students

Bruin Advisor

University of California, Los Angeles

October 2017 – May 2020

- UCLA Early Academic Outreach Program (EAOP) serving underserved Pasadena Unified School District (PUSD) high schools
- Conducted independent site visits and coordinated events with high school counselors and administration
- Mentored 9th through 12th grade students on college readiness

Student Volunteer

Project Literacy at UCLA

September 2016 – October 2017

- Provided one-on-one tutoring to children and adults in underserved communities across Los Angeles County (Vernon, Watts, East LA)